

DESIGNER

VIVIENNE WESTWOOD



△ FASHION REVOLUTION

Rebel fashion visionary Vivienne Westwood wears a signature plaid bondage suit in 1977. Working alongside Malcolm McLaren, her look became the uniform of the punk movement.

GLAMOROUS ANARCHY ▷

Westwood's Spring/Summer 2012 collection, inspired by China, mixed in corsets, lace, brocade, and ticking-stripe bedspread fabrics, and dramatic make-up to glorious effect.

One of the most admired British fashion designers, Vivienne Westwood has played a key role on the British and international fashion stage for over three decades. Westwood began designing in 1971 when she opened her first shop, Let It Rock, on the King's Road, London, with partner Malcolm McLaren (1946–2010). She looked to the past for inspiration and sold teddy boy clothes reflecting delinquent youth culture, moving on to biker-inspired gear with black leather and zips. Rebranding their store Sex (1975), they advertised their ambition to bring sexual experimentation and fetish to London streets. The shop soon became synonymous with punk, heavily promoted by McLaren's new band, the Sex Pistols. The look was aggressive and anarchistic. Jumpers had holes in them, and safety pins pierced cheeks and lips. T-shirts were slashed, and emblazoned with provocative images, studs, and slogans. The bondage look became integral to the punk genre, using leather and rubber. In particular, trousers were adorned with bondage straps and chains.

The romantic look

As punk fashion became absorbed into the mainstream, Westwood explored the essence of Englishness and sexual politics. Drawing again on historical costumes, she devised a new range of clothes that formed the basis of her first catwalk collection (1981). The *Pirate* range was adopted by musicians labelled the New Romantics, who embraced the baggy trousers, frills, billowing shirts, and lavish colours that were inspired by 18th-century men's clothing. The *Savage* collection (1982) gravitated towards a tribal look, with rough, distressed fabrics and exposed seams, while *Buffalo Girls* (also known as

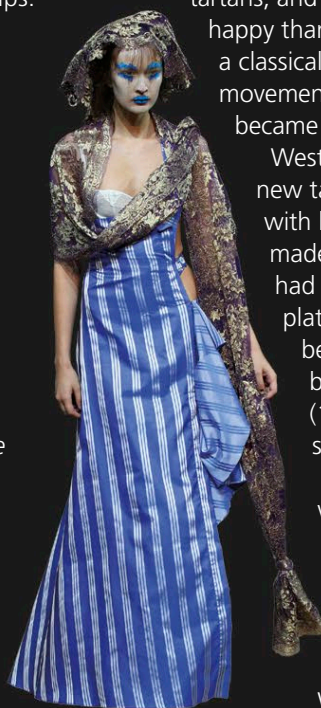
Nostalgia of Mud) garments of 1982–83 were made from combinations of twisted, oversized asymmetrical cuts of layered material, inspired by Third World cultures.

Body-shaping design

The corset emerged as a key element, along with other body-shaping pieces such as the crinoline, bustle, and towering shoe. While in Italy in the mid-80s Westwood developed the Mini-Crini, featuring shortened 19th-century-style crinolines teamed with tailored jackets – the antithesis of 1980s masculine power dressing. She later combined the style with traditional British fabrics such as Harris Tweed and Scottish tartans. Her *Anglomaniya* collection (1993–94) ran with the theme with mini kilts, gowns, newly created tartans, and tweeds. Westwood said, "I am never more happy than when I parody the British in the context of a classical perspective." Designs constricted posture and movement and emphasized the hips. Underwear became outerwear, with bras worn over dresses.

Westwood's *Café Society* collection (1994) was a new take on the hourglass silhouette. Collaborating with her partner Andreas Kronthaler, bustles were made from cushions and cages, voluminous dresses had long trains, and busts were padded. Famously, platform shoes were extremely high. She later became inspired by the costumes in paintings by French artist Jean-Antoine Watteau (1684–1721), creating sumptuous, strapless gowns made of silk taffeta.

By the end of the 1990s Westwood was firmly established as one of the most important designers in the world. She launched a fragrance line and opened new labels. Despite being made a Dame of the British Empire in 2006, her clothes are still subversive. Rooted in the classics, Westwood remains unflinchingly cutting edge.



TIMELINE

1971 Westwood and partner, Malcolm McLaren, open their London shop Let It Rock

1976 The Sex Pistols play their first gig wearing Westwood designs

1981 Her first catwalk show, *Pirate*, borrows heavily from history and inspires the look of the New Romantics

1982–83 *Buffalo* and *Punkature* are shown in Paris to critical acclaim. Her innovative designs are widely copied

1989–91 Appointed Professor of Fashion at Vienna Academy of Applied Arts. Shows first menswear collection in Florence



1993 Designs her own tartan and tweed for *Anglomaniya* collection. Includes staggeringly high platform shoes

1994 The British Fashion Council names Westwood designer of the year as she launches her new Red Label

1996 Vivienne Westwood Man is launched, and she opens stores in London, New York, Tokyo, and Milan



2011 The Spring/Summer menswear collection sets the trend for a relaxed informal style with plaid trousers

○ 1970

○ 1980

○ 1985

○ 1990

○ 1995

○ 2000